

**Op-Ed**

**Our Library Card is Our First Utility**

Amanda M. Clark

Morgridge College of Education, University of Denver

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Professor Ashley Brown

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## **Our Library Card is Our First Utility**

**By Amanda Clark**

My family has moved six times in the last 14 years. We've lived in two different countries, three different states, one province, and seven different cities. Each time we move, our library card is our first utility. We're about to move again and one of our very first stops will be the public library. You might ask why on Earth we wouldn't first sign up for internet service. We would but often long-distance moves operate on flexible windows, not fixed dates. Also, it can take internet service providers anywhere from two days to two months to get certain homes connected. We've run into every delay you can imagine: scheduling nightmares, technician shortages, incorrect equipment delivery, and even infrastructure hurdles; you name it, we've seen it. But this isn't a story about internet service providers. This is a story about libraries.

When we walked into the Georgetown Public Library and asked for a library card, the librarian at the reference desk asked to see a photo ID and proof of residency. We used our driver's licenses and our lease agreement but any photo ID and any document with your new address on it will usually suffice. The librarian created our accounts, gave us our new library cards, and we were using the library's free Wi-Fi within minutes to confidently coordinate the tail-end of our move from the Pacific Northwest to Central Texas. Considering the number of accounts, companies, subscriptions, utilities, and agencies you have to update your address with when you move, it is comforting to know that if there is something you've overlooked before the move, the public library is there to provide you with digital access at no cost and without fear of the roaming charges that a cell phone provider may charge. Moving is an abnormally busy and stressful endeavor, but the public library can be your saving grace.

Pro tip! Some public libraries don't require proof of residency and will allow you to access the internet with a "Computer Use Only" card if you happen to forget to bring proof of residency with you.

While our family is fortunate enough to be able to afford reliable home internet service, we are acutely aware of the many families in this community and across the nation that lack this modern necessity. We need not look far for evidence of this digital divide. Many folks sit just outside of the library or in the library parking lot to utilize the library's free Wi-Fi during off hours. My family's experience is just one example that relying on the public library for digital access is not limited to our economically vulnerable or under-resourced neighbors. In recent reports, the Urban Libraries Council and the Public Library Association have found that in-library Wi-Fi sessions, mobile hot-spot lending, library computer usage, high-speed upgrades, and "digital navigator" programming have all seen significant increases (Urban Libraries Council, 2025) (Public Library Association, 2024). Maintaining public funding for these library services is imperative.

While popular media may often depict libraries as silent storehouses of frozen thoughts, thick with the smell of dust and musty yellowed paper, a modern library is far more likely to be filled with the sounds of curiosity and community and to smell like coffee and pastries. The proposed departmental funding cuts in the most recent draft of the City of Georgetown's annual budget will have a negative impact on our library's ability to provide essential digital services to our community members. The library is referred to as the "third space" because it is free, welcoming, and full of community, where home is the first space and work is the second. For my family, though, the library is the first space, the space that allows us to turn a house into a home by letting us connect for free while we transition. They are the first place we belong and the first place we can function without worry. Cutting funding to one of the most powerful resources any city can provide to its residents removes the very services that make a community livable.

### References

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